

Becoming the Teacher I Needed

Piter Garcia | Writing Sample

My personal statement begins from a simple truth: I did not come into teaching because school was straightforward for me. I came into teaching because I know what it feels like to move through institutions that can see brilliance and struggle at the same time, but only know how to reward one of them. I know what it means to be intellectually capable while also navigating chronic illness, neurodivergence, cultural translation, and the pressure to perform competence in ways that make adults comfortable. Teaching, for me, is not an abstract professional choice. It is a response to lived experience and a commitment to becoming the kind of educator who recognizes complexity in students before reducing them to a label.

I am a Dominican-American, first-generation scholar, data scientist, and teacher candidate completing certification in K-12 Computer Science alongside advanced work in disability and inclusive practices. My pathway into education has not been linear. I bring with me training in computer science, engineering, data science, and bioinformatics, as well as years of technical problem solving and interdisciplinary research. But the deeper reason I am here is that I have become convinced that teaching is one of the most consequential sites where equity either becomes real or remains only rhetorical. Schools do not simply deliver content. They decide whose ways of thinking count, whose language is recognized as intelligent, whose behavior is interpreted with generosity, and whose needs are framed as inconvenient.

That reality is especially urgent in computer science education. Computer science is often presented as neutral, objective, and meritocratic, but classroom practice tells a different story. Access to technology, confidence with tools, cultural familiarity with computing, language load, disability supports, and classroom participation norms all shape who gets to see themselves as "good at" computer science. I want to teach computer science in a way that interrupts the idea that it belongs only to students who are already fluent in dominant academic and technological norms. My goal is to make computing a space where students can encounter problem solving, creativity, logic, collaboration, and authorship as human capacities they already possess - not as credentials they have to earn before they are allowed to belong.

My commitment to inclusive teaching is rooted in both scholarship and autobiography. Over the past year, I have had to reckon more directly with my own neurodivergence and the ways I learned, as a student, to mask difficulty until it became invisible to others and corrosive to me. That process has changed how I read students. I am increasingly aware that what adults often call "behavior," "defiance," "lack of focus," or "poor communication" may actually be evidence of cognitive overload, unmet support needs, linguistic mismatch, fear, shame, or prior experiences of being misunderstood. I want my classroom to be one where the interpretive pause is built into pedagogy: before I punish, I ask what the student is communicating; before I assume inability, I look for evidence of competence; before I demand sameness, I consider whether the structure itself needs to change.

My practicum and coursework have strengthened this stance. In my elementary placements, I have seen how quickly students become positioned as "the problem" when adults interpret visible frustration through a compliance lens. I have also seen how fast that positioning can change when a student is given a

purposeful role, a co-regulating adult, an alternate pathway into the task, or language that narrates competence rather than deficit. Those moments have convinced me that inclusion is not a sentiment. It is a set of concrete professional moves: designing flexible participation structures, communicating expectations clearly, making room for multiple forms of expression, and building relationships sturdy enough to hold students through difficulty.

My teaching philosophy is therefore grounded in four commitments.

First, I believe learning is relational. Students learn best when they experience classrooms as places where they are known, not merely managed. Relationship is not separate from instruction; it is part of the instructional architecture. In a computer science classroom, this means learning students' interests, validating different problem-solving approaches, and creating norms that let students take risks without fear of humiliation.

Second, I believe equity requires design, not just intention. It is not enough to care about students. I have to build lessons, routines, assessments, and technologies that reduce unnecessary barriers. This includes using universal design principles, trauma-informed practices, explicit scaffolds, multimodal expression, and language supports that make participation possible for more learners.

Third, I believe teaching computer science is an ethical act. AI, algorithms, data, and digital tools are not socially neutral. Students need opportunities to learn not only how technologies work, but how they shape power, access, privacy, authorship, and belonging. I want students to leave my classroom not just as competent users or creators of technology, but as thoughtful people who can question the systems they are asked to trust.

Fourth, I believe reflection is part of professional responsibility. I do not want to become the kind of teacher who hides behind routine or treats expertise as finished. I want to remain porous to feedback, willing to revise, and honest about the biases I still carry. My growth as a teacher depends on my willingness to study my own assumptions with the same seriousness I bring to curriculum and instruction.

The comprehensive portfolio that follows represents this philosophy in practice. It is a synthesis of the work I have done across my program: reflections, lesson plans, unit designs, inclusive practice analyses, collaborative projects, and clinical observations. Each proficiency paper shows not only what I have learned, but how I am learning to braid together identity, theory, pedagogical judgment, and classroom action. Together, they document the teacher I am becoming: a teacher who wants students - especially those most often misread by schools - to encounter rigor without erasure, structure without humiliation, and opportunity without having to abandon who they are.

Teaching, for me, is ultimately about dignity. I want students to leave my classroom more intellectually alive, more agentic, and more convinced that their minds matter. If I can help build that kind of classroom, then I am not only doing the work of certification. I am doing the work that brought me here in the first place.

Source: Public teaching-portfolio statement, preserved without substantive revision for this application writing sample.